C1 Writing

Essay introductions and conclusions

Open with a clear context and thesis, and close by drawing your argument together, not by repeating it.

Examiners read the first and last paragraphs most carefully. A strong introduction tells the reader what the essay will argue; a strong conclusion shows what the argument adds up to.

Introduction: three moves

Move	Example
1. Context (general to specific)	*Remote work, once a rare perk, has become standard in many industries.*
2. The issue	*This shift raises the question of whether productivity rises or falls when staff work from home.*
3. Thesis and outline	*This essay argues that remote work improves productivity for focused tasks but weakens collaboration, and considers how companies can balance the two.*

Conclusion: three moves

Move	Example
1. Restate the thesis in new words	*Working from home, then, is neither a cure-all nor a threat.*
2. Synthesise the main points	*Its gains in concentration are real, yet they come at the cost of informal learning between colleagues.*
3. Wider implication or recommendation	*Companies that combine both, with office days for collaboration, are likely to gain the most.*

Write the conclusion first, in note form. Knowing where you will end keeps every paragraph pointed in the same direction.

Common mistakes. Opening with a dictionary definition or a cliché (*Since the dawn of time...*), and adding a new argument in the conclusion. The conclusion should only use points the essay has already made.

Practice

1. Which is the better opening? (a) "The dictionary defines tourism as..." (b) "Tourism now supports one in ten jobs worldwide, yet many residents of popular cities resent it."
2. Write a thesis for: Should university education be free?
3. What is wrong with this conclusion sentence? "Another important point is that free education reduces crime."
4. Rewrite without repeating the thesis word for word: Thesis: "Social media harms teenagers' mental health." Conclusion: "In conclusion, social media harms teenagers' mental health."

▼ **Show answers**

1. (b): it gives specific context and sets up a tension.
2. For example: This essay argues that free university education benefits society as a whole, provided it is funded through targeted taxation rather than cuts elsewhere.
3. It introduces a new argument that the essay has not discussed.
4. For example: Overall, the evidence suggests that heavy social media use poses real risks to young people's wellbeing.